table, graphically described that cutting oil to the GDR would cause ‘enormous losses across the whole of the economy’.22 While Baibakov argued for understanding, his response of ‘nothing can be done’, came as a bitter disappointment.

In turn, to soothe the East Germans, Brezhnev sent his Central Committee secretary for international relations, Konstantin Russakow, to Berlin to explain that ‘a great disaster has befallen us, something that has not happened since the creation of the Soviet Union. If you don’t bear the consequences with us, there is the danger that the Soviet Union cannot maintain its international position.’

For effect, Russakov added that Brezhnev instructed him to: ‘tell Erich, I cried when I wrote the letters. We have calculated everything. We cannot expect more from our people.’ Unmoved, Honecker said the GDR could not be made liable for Russia’s plight and warned of the consequences, saying the shortage would undermine the people’s trust in the party and state leadership. ‘We are deeply affected by your misfortune, but the GDR must remain stable.’ As his emotion battled with judgment, a particularly revealing insight into Honecker’s confidence (and deep anxiety) came when he slipped in the threat that the GDR might curtail its own deliveries of uranium to the Soviet Union.23

Before long, Honecker was branching out toward the Federal Republic. Subsequently, his twice-postponed meeting with Helmut Schmidt took place in December 1981 and proved, mercifully, free of petty wrangles. In his dealings with Bonn, Honecker secured a six-month extension of an interest-free overdraft, expanding the GDR’s financial scope for a few months. However, Schmidt was unable to achieve the abolition of stiff compulsory exchange rates for Western visitors to the GDR, which had increased from DM13 to DM25 per day. Assessing his adversary, Schmidt thought Honecker a ‘gifted political tactician’, but relatively subdued and lacking in self-assurance.24 ‘It never became clear to me,’ Schmidt recounted, ‘how this mediocre man was able to stay at the head of the Politburo for so long.’25

He listened politely as Honecker rattled-off pre-prepared orations on European security, including the barb: ‘Good neighbourliness cannot